Barbareek

written by

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SWA
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BLACK:

MAHESH (V.O.)
Papa, why do we call him Barbareek?

JANARDAN (V.O.)
Because in the Mahabharata, Barbareek chose to fight not for his family, but for the opposite side, because it was weak...

FADE IN:

EXT. VILLAGE CENTER - NIGHT

A small temple in the middle of an empty community area. Hill is visible in the background, albeit faded due to the thick fog. The temple is about 10 feet tall — Victorian architecture, white in color, redstone at the entrance stairs.

The old-English inscription on the stone says- 'SHREE ISAAC ANDERSON- 1857-1916', in DEVANAGRI SCRIPT.

SUPER ON THE SCREEN - '1921, British India'

We glide towards the temple, and under the dimmed light of a burning incense, a cloud of thin smoke, and an oil lamp, we see a life-sized sculpture of the deity, ISAAC ANDERSON. Clad in Red British General attire, the sculpture has all the rank badges on its shoulders, cuffs, and collars, signaling a respectable position within the British government.

Through the silence of the night, we hear whispers and a chatter of kids.

CUT TO:

Three kids pass by the temple, laughing, chattering incessantly. Moonlight illuminating their path, they are determined and KNOW where they are headed.

The kids are KISNA, MAHESH, and RAJU. Barefoot, shirtless, their lower half covered in dirty dhoti, the kids are all about 10-12 years old. They look like they're up to some forbidden shenanigans as they move around the village like a bunch of spying kittens.

KISNA
Careful, let's not make any sound. We almost got caught yesterday. Whose turn is it today?

RAJU
It was me yesterday, you the day before that. Mahesh!

Raju looks at Mahesh.

Mahesh throws an approving nod at them, exhaling vapor from his mouth. The spring has almost arrived; it's still cold, but the kids don't know cold.

They walk quietly, yet quickly. In a BIRD'S- EYE - shot, we peek into the direction they are headed. It IS an old, huge mansion.

CUT TO:

EXT. THE MANSION - NIGHT

The kids are facing the mansion, standing right outside the tall gate, which is nameless, and worn down, seemingly ancient (was built in the 1700s for British Holiday retreats to the hills in the peak Delhi summers).

Mahesh has a stone in his hand. He tightens his fist around the stone. The misty, grassy ground beneath him has dampened his feet. There's eeriness in the atmosphere.

The Mansion stands at the edge of the hill, with a valley on both sides. It faces the village, and two scary gargoyles adorn the gate.

Mahesh throws a stone, which flies above the gate and hits the main door of the mansion.

A loud thud irritates the nocturnal insects.

The stone falls on the steel plate placed right outside the door. And now it also has a stone along with leftover food.

The kids stare at the door, anxious yet excited. No movement at the door.

Mahesh picks up another stone and takes the stance to throw it with more strength.

Just then, a loud, scary growl tears through the silence of the night, echoing from the mansion. The kids laugh, they turn back and begin running towards the village, cheering victoriously.

We stay at the Mansion for a bit, and through the tall 4-foot window, carved right beside the door, we observe a shadowy figure appear at the window, holding something like a lamp.

CUT TO:

INT. MAHESH'S HOUSE - NIGHT

SHERU, the pet dog, barks in wild excitement as his master, Mahesh, sneaks into the house, slick like a kitten, trying to enter the bedroom without getting caught. Mahesh attempts to shush the dog, but Sheru's excitement is unhinged and loud.

Mahesh's face shows it all. He realizes he should have thought of this before he sneaked out.

His mother, Savitri, 30, walks out of the bedroom, faces Mahesh, and she is angry! Mahesh is caught red-handed.

CUT TO:

INT. MAHESH'S HOUSE - BEDROOM-NIGHT

Mahesh is sitting on a mat, his mother oiling her hair harshly, as if she's taking out her frustration on her lush, beautiful, black hair. She looks beautiful in the illumination of a yellow dim lamp, even with that child-like scowl on her face.

Sheru is squatted beside them, licking his paws.

SAVITRI
You refuse to grow up, huh?

Mahesh's guilt is explicitly observed. He looks down, scratching his fingernails.

Savitri's scowl turns into a concerning look. She comes closer and holds his hand. Stickiness transferred to Mahesh's hands. He tries to wipe the oil from his torn, cotton dhoti and the white kurta now covering his upper body.

SAVITRI (CONT'D)
You know what blasphemy is? He's a protector, but that doesn't mean he can't get angry.

Mahesh looks up at his beautiful mother, who is genuinely concerned.

MAHESH
But Mom, why did you give him my share of food? What kind of a protector is he if he can't arrange his own food?

Savitri smirks. Mahesh's innocence always wins her over.

SAVITRI
Son, if a little sacrifice seals your devotion and makes the protector kinder towards you.
(MORE)

SAVITRI (CONT'D)
It's good, right? I am doing this for your sake.

MAHESH
Making me sleep hungry is not my 'sake'. KOODERAM uncle is rich. He should be the only one giving food to the protector.

SAVITRI
Oh, so you only want Kooderam to be protected from outside danger?

Mahesh isn't satisfied with this argument. His questioning eyes are widened.

MAHESH
What's he protecting us against anyway? We have nothing. Who would come here to steal or loot?

He has tears in his eyes.

Sheru, lying beside, is silently observing them both, and then suddenly, his ears flap a bit, he raises his head, and becomes attentive as if he heard something that shouldn't be there in the house. He turns his head towards the door.

SAVITRI
You don't get it. Okay, I will ask your father to send more money. But Gandhiji has started this new movement against the British; I will work more to ensure enough food on the table for both you and Shree Barbareek ji. Okay?

CUT TO:

A shadow lurks outside the bedroom. A man in a squatting position, face tied with a white cotton cloth, only his eyes visible. It's MOTI (27), and he's keenly listening to the conversation taking place between Savitri and Mahesh.

MAHESH
But Mom, Kisna's father said the Britisher died in that big fire. And that he's just a ghost now, who just spooks little children and eats all our food. How can a ghost be a protector?

SAVITRI
He's a teacher in the nearby town, son. You study too much, and you become crazy. We don't need to believe everything. Sometimes, it's a matter of faith.

Just then, Moti makes a blunder. In an attempt to scratch his head, his elbow hits the water clay pot put right behind him. The pot falls and breaks. LOUD SPLASH!

Moti is numb. He sits motionless.

Hell breaks loose in Sheru's ears, and he jumps up, dashes towards the closed bedroom door, barking at the door like he's faced with his mortal enemy.

Mahesh and Savitri are confused. She rushes to the door and opens it.

SAVITRI (CONT'D)
Who's there?

Moti panics as Sheru darts out of the bedroom and begins barking at Moti, who is now terrified.

Savitri walks out and screams 'THIEF' as Moti stands numbly right in front of her.

Mahesh rushes in with a stick in his hands, and Moti turns back and darts outside.

CUT TO:

EXT. MAHESH'S HOUSE - NIGHT

Moti jumps through the small compound wall of the house and enters the main street.

Sheru chases after him and barks at Moti from a safe distance, as Savitri and Mahesh emerge from the house and approach the old, muddy house's entrance.

SAVITRI
THIEF! THIEF!

She screams at the top of her lungs.

Suddenly, the street becomes alive with chatter erupting in nearby houses, and lamps are being lit.

Moti stands in the middle of the street, confused.

From the adjacent house, HEERA (30) emerges, another thief. A villager is chasing him with a stick.

He jumps towards Moti, grabs his hand, and begins running.

The villagers swarm the streets, chasing the thieves with sticks and knives, and other weapons, and scream in anger.

CUT TO:

EXT. VILLAGE CENTER - NIGHT

Heera and Moti are at the center of the village, clueless. Screaming villagers can be heard from all corners. Behind them IS THE TEMPLE. Heera turns towards it.

MOTI
Brother, what should we do?

HEERA
Shut up. Let me think.

Moti and Heera jog around in circles as the villagers' chatter slowly fades in.

Villagers emerge from all sides, closing in on the brothers.

Moti has given up. He joins his palms in a prayer, sobbing. Heera is still in a defensive mode, trying to find a way out of this life-threatening mess.

Heera grabs Moti's hand and begins running towards the temple. They climb the stairs and stand near the statue of Isaac.

The villagers approach them in fury and surround the temple, NOT ENTERING.

Heera and Moti are panting, sweating hard. Heera pulls his slippers in his hand to defend himself and to protect Moti, who's cowering behind him.

The villagers are now just a foot away from the temple. The thieves are trapped.

Villagers clearly don't like the thieves entering their sacred temple, that too with shoes on! A villager with a headgear seems to be the SARPANCH, 40, the head of the village committee.

SARPANCH
Aye, come out!

JOGI
Are you even aware of what you are doing right now? At least put your shoes out.

Moti looks around and realizes it's a temple. He quickly removes his shoes and moves to put them out. Heera grabs one of his shoes and throws them at the villagers. The villagers react aggressively.

HEERA
Come closer, and you'll die.

The villagers are angry, but they're hesitant to approach them.

Moti's hopeful eyes glance at the villagers and his brother in one breath.

Heera is still in his senses. He knows what's up. An arrogant smirk adorns his face.

One of the villagers is old and a little cautious.

SATTU
Brother, let's talk calmly. You know, one should not enter the temple after sunset. And that too with your shoes on. Just come out, and we will let you go. No harm done.

HEERA
You think I'm a fool? You'll kill us the moment we step down.

SATTU
Oh brother. You didn't steal anything anyway, right? Just come out, we are all brothers here.

Sattu approaches a step closer.

Heera's eyes catch a hold of the shining sword in Isaac's statue's right hand.

In one swift motion, he pulls it out of the sculpture.

The villagers gasp.

In their eyes, there is anger, shock, and dismay at the same time.

A woman from the crowd faints and falls to the ground. Two other women are quick to pick her up and take her back.

Heera laughs like a maniac. Moti turns pale.

HEERA
What a bunch of halfwits. Should I break the idol?

He touches the sculpture with the sword. The villagers are shocked.

SARPANCH
No... No... please don't. We are requesting you, for your sake only. This is blasphemy. You'll have to pay for this. You are like our brothers. Please step down respectfully.

Heera becomes cocky.

HEERA
Who'll make us pay?
(pointing towards the idol) THIS?

Sarpanch puts his stick down, walks a step back, and instructs everyone else to do the same. Everyone follows his words.

Heera teases the villagers, brings his sword towards the statue in a swift motion, and stops right at its neck.

The villagers gasp again.

SARPANCH
Okay, brother. We'll leave. It's fine.

The villagers chatter among themselves and begin leaving one by one.

Heera has pride on his face, and Moti is a bit relieved.

Within minutes, the villagers disappear. The village center is empty again. And silent.

MOTI
Brother, let's leave.

However, Heera's eyes are carefully scrutinizing the surroundings. He knows something is up. He whispers.

HEERA
Moti, look carefully...

Moti looks closely, in the dark, amidst a thin layer of fog, and finds people hiding behind the houses, waiting for the moment to strike. He swallows.

Heera looks up at the moon and then in a particular direction to gauge where they should run to escape.

Moti is terrified.

HEERA (CONT'D)
Moti, when I say RUN, you run... In the direction of my right ear. Keep running until I tell you to stop. Got it?

Heera tilts his body slightly.

Moti looks in the direction of his right ear...

Moti swallows. It's dead silent. Their breaths are shallow, and they can hear their heartbeats.

It's cold outside, yet they are both drenched in sweat. Heera wipes away a thick layer of sweat from his brow.

Heera is closely observing his surroundings. He shuts his eyes, takes a deep breath.

HEERA (CONT'D)
(whispering)
Moti...

Moti is shaking.

HEERA (CONT'D)
RUN!

And they jump down from the temple, and begin darting towards the right.

And CHAOS ERUPTS!

The screaming group of men and women thrusts forth from their hiding and chases after them.

CUT TO:

EXT. VILLAGE BORDER - NIGHT

Heera is paving the way through the trees and weeds, holding Moti's hand. Moti is mindlessly following Heera through every nook and cranny of the village forest, barefoot.

Moti screams, and they stop. Heera looks at his brother's bleeding foot. He removes his own shoes haphazardly and puts them on his brother's feet. They resume running.

And finally, they arrive at the edge of a hill, where stands THE MANSION.

EXT. MANSION - NIGHT

To their left is a deep valley, and also to their right. They stop at the gate.

Rabid villagers are closing in.

MOTI
Brother, what now?

Heera can't believe he made such a blunder. He is frustrated. He looks at the moon.

Heera's eyes are stuck on the approaching villagers, who are now about 100 meters away.

MOTI (CONT'D)
Brother...